

THE FIGHT FOR freedom

THE SLAVE TRADE

From the 1400s to the end of the 1800s, European powers captured, bought, and sold people of African descent as commodities in what was known as the transatlantic slave trade. African slaves, who survived horrific conditions on overcrowded slave ships, were forced to labor without pay in European colonies across the Atlantic. About 12.5 million slaves were shipped to North America, South America (Brazil was the world's biggest importer), and the Caribbean, but only 10.7 million survived the passage. More than half of the slaves were transported there during the 18th century, when demand for labor rose with the growth of plantations for cash crops such as tobacco and sugar.

Slavery affected African women in a distinct way: they faced sexism and racism, and were vulnerable to sexual violence and coercion. Despite crushing oppression, enslaved women resisted their condition by various means including escape, infanticide, suicide, and feigning sickness or pregnancy.

▼ Slave shackles

These iron ankle shackles chained captives together on tightly packed slave ships. A large number of those forcibly taken were women of childbearing age, and sexual abuse was widespread on ships.



Working the fields

Although Western cultural norms considered women unsuited to manual labor, enslaved African men and women often did the same work. They toiled side by side in tobacco fields in Virginia, under an overseer who was usually armed with a whip or a pistol. On Caribbean sugar plantations, women worked in the cane fields in the grueling heat, and risked physical harm in the sugar mills. To justify women doing the field labor that white women were not believed capable of performing, slave-owning European colonialists characterized black women as subhuman. Some slaveholders even

